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ORIGINAL PAPER

Becoming bilingual (or not): A look into the public's intersecting orientations towards Bilingual 2030 in multilingual Taiwan

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Abstract

The Bilingual 2030 policy in Taiwan has attracted both support and criticism since it was introduced in 2018. Those who embrace the policy consider it an opportunity for Taiwan to become more globally connected, while those who are skeptical question whether the policy could actually lead Taiwan to a better place in the longer run—not just linguistically, but also socially, economically, and politically. Driven by this concern, this paper seeks to systematically examine the public's response towards Bilingual 2030—through the analysis of opinion pieces and polls collected between 2019 and 2022, in addition to a series of comments gathered from a policy petition filed in 2023. With Ruiz's (NABE J 8:15–34, 1984) theory as a guiding framework, this paper shows that the public's language orientations are relational, intersecting, and multilayered, implicated in wider language power dynamics. In particular, the findings unveil a disconnect between what is projected and what is received, moving from an English-as-resource focus to a more dynamic discussion of resource, right, and problem orientations associated with different languages in Taiwan. While there is ample discussion around the economic benefits of English, issues related to national identity and de/colonization are also very much alive and kicking in interpretations of the policy. The main argument of this paper is that the "bilingual" label in policy discourse needs to be taken more critically and in ways that address the language concerns of the people. The paper ends with some suggestions to advance the vision of enhancing multilingual Taiwan.

Keywords Language policy and planning · Bi/multilingualism · Language orientations · Language-as-resource · Language-as-right · Language-as-problem

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Introduction

> In order to promote our nation's economic development, in the near term we will pursue the policy goal of developing Taiwan into a bilingual nation, and gradually advance toward the long-term goal of English as our official language—William Lai Ching-te.

In December 2018, the Taiwanese government announced a groundbreaking blueprint to develop Taiwan into a bilingual nation by 2030 (National Development Council, 2018). The quote above, from the then premier and now president of Taiwan, Mr. Lai, succinctly encapsulates the vision behind the bilingual dream: to enhance the competitiveness of Taiwan through the promotion of English. While the blueprint is now renamed as Bilingual 2030 after several rounds of revision, the role of English in the policy remains unshakable (Chang, 2022; Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Yeh, 2023), competing for attention and resources with other existing languages in Taiwan.

Officially known as the Republic of China, Taiwan has been and continues to be a site of linguistic struggle, an outcome shaped by successive waves of immigration, colonization, and agendas put forward by different interest groups. Since the Chinese nationalists arrived to Taiwan in the mid twentieth century, Mandarin has accumulated and consolidated its power through a series of top-down linguistic control. In 1987 when the Martial Law was lifted, the dominance of Mandarin persisted in spite of growing movements to emphasize internationalization and indigenization (Chen, 2010; Dupré, 2014). Today, while there are no languages in Taiwan assigned official status, all mother tongues (e.g., Mandarin, Tâi-gí,[1] Hakka, a variety of indigenous languages) of local ethnic groups and Taiwan Sign Language have since 2019 received recognition and protection under the National Languages Development Act (Ministry of Culture, 2019). According to the most recent census conducted in Taiwan (National Statistics, 2020), 96.8% of the Taiwanese population use Mandarin either as their primary or secondary language for communication. All other national languages have varying degrees of vitality.

Against this language backdrop and the complex geopolitical position of Taiwan, what has been the public's response towards Bilingual 2030? More specifically, how has the idea of "becoming bilingual" been perceived and understood by Taiwanese? As the success or failure of a policy depends on how it is received by the public, studying the public's response offers insights into people's concerns, needs, and desires, which in turn could help fine-tune existing plans in ways that meet the interests and values of those who are affected (Easlick, 2022; Leung, 2016). With Ruiz's (1984) conceptualization of language orientations as a guiding framework, this paper sets out to systematically explore answers to the two questions above—through the analysis of opinion pieces, polls, and comments gathered from a recent

[1] Tâi-gí is also known as Taiwanese, Hokkien, or Southern Min. While both Tâi-gí and Taiwanese are names that are widely used by its speakers, Tâi-gí is adopted in this paper to prevent readers from mistakenly assuming that Taiwanese is the only language spoken by the Taiwanese people.

petition related to the bilingual policy. By capturing voices from the public, this paper shows that people's language orientations are relational, intersecting, and multilayered, implicated in wider language power dynamics. In particular, the findings unveil a disconnect between what is projected (an English-as-resource focus in policy discourse) and what is received (a more dynamic discussion of resource, right, and problem orientations in public discourse associated with different languages in Taiwan). The main argument of this paper is that the "bilingual" label needs to be taken more critically and in ways that address the language concerns of the people. The paper ends with some suggestions to advance the vision of enhancing multilingual Taiwan.

A brief outline of the development of Bilingual 2030

Before turning to the literature review, a brief outline of the development of Bilingual 2030 is presented here to highlight some key debates surrounding the policy since its inception. In particular, the bilingual policy in Taiwan can be marked by two important changes: from making English an official language to constructing a bilingual nation (National Development Council, 2018), and from constructing a bilingual nation to imagining Bilingual 2030 (National Development Council, 2021).

The first key change that emerged was the transition from making English an official language in Taiwan to the revised plan of constructing a bilingual nation. The idea of giving English an official status—though not a new call in Taiwan—was primarily advocated by Mr. Lai following his success in promoting English in Tainan when he served as mayor there between 2010 and 2017. In 2017, this vision was brought to the parliament when Lai became the premier (and then vice president in 2020 before being elected as president in 2024); however, the municipal-turned-national plan was met with widespread suspicion among academics. The suspicion stemmed from several concerns, including insufficient debate prior to the announcement of the policy, the lack of justification for attributing such privileged status to English, and that there is no existing first official language in Taiwan to begin with for English to become the second official language. Within a few months, these concerns were acknowledged but only partially addressed: the plan to elevate the status of English was halted, and replaced with the Blueprint for Developing Taiwan into a Bilingual Nation by 2030.

In spite of the name change, the move from making English an official language to constructing a bilingual nation was short-lived. While there is a lack of conceptual clarity in what "bilingual" refers to, English-Mandarin bilingualism is assumed in the policy. The term "nation" further creates confusion as to whether English-Mandarin bilingualism should be utilized to represent Taiwan, putting the hard-won status of other national languages under threat (Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Yeh, 2023). In the early spring of 2022, the heated discussion surrounding the bilingual nation proposal reached its height when the Taiwan Languages & Literature Society organized a petition to replace bilingual nation with "English-friendly, multilingual Taiwan", and when a number of scholars from the fields of linguistics, education, and cultural

studies held a panel calling for the reconsideration of the policy itself (Liao, 2022). The panel was widely received by the public; together with the petition, it ultimately led to the removal of "nation" in the policy name. The main content of the policy, however, stayed mostly the same.

Literature review

Having outlined some key events that have shaped what Bilingual 2030 is today, the literature review moves on to cover three areas in the development of the policy that will be further unpacked with the broader research literature related to language status planning and language acquisition planning. The three areas are 1) labeling a language as official, 2) foregrounding nation in language planning, and 3) managing linguistic diversity through specific forms of bilingual education.

Labeling a language as official

Negotiating language status in multilingual jurisdictions is never an ideologically neutral process. As aptly described by Leung (2016), any language decision, "at whatever level of explicit policy formation it is made, creates a status hierarchy, reshapes identity, and affects relationships between linguistic communities" (p. 372). There are different labels that assign status to languages, and the most prestigious one is perhaps labeling a language as "official" due to the authority it denotes. According to UNESCO (2006), an official language refers to a language designated by law to be employed in the public domain. In this sense, a language is official when states are committed to using that language in a wide range of operations, although enshrining a language as official in law does not necessarily mean that it would penetrate all functions of state business (Leung, 2016; Wright, 2012). Additionally, not all states have declared official languages; for those that do, the official languages can be indigenous, imported, or a combination of both. As there are usually fewer languages to be recognized as official than the actual number of languages spoken by different communities within a state, the competition for legitimacy exposes the value systems of these multilingual societies, and sometimes "the battlefield of class and racial politics" that underpin them (Leung, 2016, p. 373).

Around the world, several states have English as an official language, but the exact number varies because of how the concept of state is defined and whether both "de facto" and "de jure" official statuses are counted (e.g., Berlitz.com claims 67; the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Taiwan lists 58). Among these states, the majority are considered postcolonial contexts that have former ties with English-speaking countries. In these contexts, English is usually not the sole official language of the state, but accompanied by another local language (or set of languages) to balance the role of English (Davies & Dubinsky, 2018). Two examples in Asia, the Philippines and Singapore, are often discussed regarding this linguistic arrangement. In the Philippines, Tagalog-based Filipino and English are the two official languages of the state, even though there are more than a hundred languages spoken on the ground

(Tupas & Martin, 2017). Similar to the multilingual reality in the Philippines, in Singapore, Mandarin, Malay, Tamil, and English are the four languages with official status. On the state level, bilingualism has been promoted since the 1960s, constructed as part of a larger multiracial system mandating students to learn English along with the assigned mother tongue of their race (Lu, 2021). Specifically, Mandarin, Malay, and Tamil serve as mother tongues due to their strengthened links with culture and heritage. English, however, is not treated by the state as a mother tongue; instead, it is considered the language for interethnic communication and communication with the outside world.

While the language arrangement in the Philippines and Singapore present examples of how English can be made an official language in the linguistic ecology of a multilingual state, their historical connections with the United States and the British empire respectively should not be overlooked.[2] The penetration of English is so deep that few postcolonial societies have been able to rid themselves from the strong influence of English. Yet, this is not to say that countries with no American or British ties have not or cannot adopt English as an official language. Take the unusual case of Rwanda as an example: English is included as one of the official languages along with Kinyarwanda, French, and Swahili. As Rwanda's interactions with its neighboring countries (e.g., Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda) are increasingly facilitated through English, the turn to English is perhaps not entirely surprising (Plonski et al., 2013). Moreover, heavy dependence on foreign aid for development may further explain why Rwanda is interested in giving English an elevated status. Whether Taiwan intends to follow the model of Rwanda is yet to be seen.

Foregrounding nation in language planning

Another key form of status planning centers on the relationship between language and nation-building (Tsui & Tollefson, 2007). In particular, the popular belief of "one nation, one language" persists, showing how ideas of nation and language continue to advance each other in modern days. As processes of nation-building comprise a discursive dimension, languages may be politicized and become a cornerstone in nationalist movements (Davies & Dubinsky, 2018; Kamusella, 2018). For this reason, languages that function as sacred symbols of a nation are often strategically labeled as "national", conceived as a unifying force to bind a population who share a specific culture or ethnicity. These languages are likely indigenous and politically significant, and may or may not simultaneously serve as official languages of the state (Davies & Dubinsky, 2018; Leung, 2016; Ruiz, 1990; UNESCO, 2006).

The positioning of English in non-English societies, specifically, has profound implications for one's national cultural identity (Tsui & Tollefson, 2007). In the two Asian cases invoked earlier, the arrangements between official languages and national languages—with English in the equation—revolve around delicate balances

[2] Taiwan, though having gone through different periods of colonization by the Dutch, Spanish, and Japanese between the seventeenth and twentieth centuries, was never a colony of any English-speaking power.

of power: in the Philippines, while both English and Filipino are labeled "official", only Filipino is at the same time "national" due to its anticolonial and literary tradition in the country's colonial history (Tupas & Martin, 2017). The representativeness of Filipino as the single national language, though, has been challenged consistently. In Singapore, Malay is both the official and national language of the state, but its status is diluted by English, Chinese, and Tamil that are assigned as official, too (Leung, 2016). Additionally, as highlighted in the previous section, when placed against English, Malay is somewhat confined to the space of culture-bearing mother tongue, yet not deemed adequate enough as a language for international communication (Lu, 2021).

As noted by Davies and Dubinsky (2018), language choices "have profound impacts on the development and the identity of a nascent country" (p. 105). This is especially relevant to the situation in Taiwan, an independently functioning state that is not yet fully recognized by the international community. Taiwan's bilingual nation proposal, according to Chang (2022), is in essence an attempt to build an imagined community founded on English, an envisioned future of Taiwanese as English-speaking, international, and competitive. Linguistically, the proposal is a double-edged sword: while "nation" seems to add legitimacy to the political reality of Taiwan, the word also triggers concerns related to possibilities of misrepresentation and self-colonization. At the same time, removing "nation" in the proposal does not eliminate questions regarding how the imposition of English would go in tandem or come into conflict with the development of all national languages in Taiwan (Dupré, 2022). As different groups vie for control over the definition of bilingualism, managing interactions between English and Taiwan's national languages is still at its core an issue of national identity (Chang, 2022; Ferrer & Lin, 2021). The policy's persistent emphasis on English also raises speculations on the government's intention to further distance itself from China, with the policy seen as presenting Taiwan an opportunity to articulate its own terms of existence on the global stage through the political and economic ties it develops (Hsu, 2021; Yeh, 2023).

Managing linguistic diversity through bilingual education

Going beyond explicit language status planning, where a language stands in a multilingual society can further be influenced by language acquisition planning; in other words, the perceived status of a language may differ based on the extent to which a language is preferred and privileged within an education system. Bilingual education—a form of education that uses more than one language (Baker, 2011; García, 2009)—is political in itself as it involves selecting languages to be emphasized in schools, increasing the number of speakers of those languages, and allocating more resources and power to the communities who speak them.

Turning again to countries in Asia but focusing on those that do not have English as an official language, ample examples unveil the diverse expressions of bilingual education. In China, while bilingual education is usually associated with the combination of Mandarin and English, it may also include Mandarin along with languages used by ethnic minorities or other regional Chinese varieties, unfolding within the

limits imposed by the state's institutionalized language order which positions Mandarin at the center (Wang & Gao, 2023; Zao et al., 2019). In Japan, bilingual education is imagined differently for different groups of population (e.g., Japanese nationals learning English vs. foreigners learning Japanese), foregrounding a "dualism that indexes national and other speaker-hood" in the management of diversity (Motobayashi, 2020, p. 1175). Similarly, bilingual education in South Korea is often discussed in relation with education provided to ethnolinguistic minorities such as refugees, migrant workers, and international marriage migrants (Sohn & Kang, 2021). Importantly, since 2010 a paradigm shift built upon a mixture of linguistic entrepreneurship and ethnocentric nationalism can be identified in Korea, moving from an emphasis on assimilation (i.e., the learning of Korean as a second language) to the promotion of neoliberal linguistic pluralism (i.e., the maintenance of languages spoken by ethnolinguistic minorities for the betterment of the host society).

In the development of Taiwan's Bilingual 2030, the compromised form of "semi-" or "quasi-" official bilingualism is manifested in the transition from status planning to acquisition planning. As noted by Ferrer and Lin (2021), the domain of education is the primary site where the bilingual policy has continued to target. A closer look into policy documents issued by the Ministry of Education shows that there is extensive coverage on approaches such as Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL), Teaching English in English (TEIE), and English medium instruction (EMI). Although Taiwan's national languages and key languages spoken by New Immigrants from Southeast Asia are not excluded from the national curriculum, in the bilingual policy they are rendered invisible. While the strong interest in English is not so different from the situation in other Asian countries (Tsui & Tollefson, 2007), Taiwan's current take on bilingual education seems to be more similar to the National Bilingual Program in Colombia than what its neighboring countries practice, as "bilingual" in both contexts foregrounds the development of English at the expense of bilingualism itself (Mackenzie, 2022).

Conceptual framework

In the literature review, key areas in the development of Bilingual 2030 were unpacked with the broader research literature related to language status planning and language acquisition planning. While identifying language planning types can be useful in mapping the focus of the policy, this alone does not help researchers fully understand the motivations that drive the policy, the directions that it could take in the future, and how the policy is received as it changes and develops. With these concerns in mind, in this paper I revisit Ruiz's (1984) conceptualization of language orientations to explore the underlying forces that guide the public's response towards Bilingual 2030. This conceptualization offers a powerful analytical lens to explain the discourses around language (Zúñiga, 2016).

As defined by Ruiz (1984), language orientations are complex dispositions toward languages and their roles in society. Because language debates often index wider sociopolitical issues (e.g., being the root of an issue or a proxy for an issue) (Bale, 2016; Price, 2020), identifying orientations in such debates is important

for policymaking. As an overview, Ruiz proposed three orientations that are frequently observed in language policy and planning: language-as-problem, language-as-right, and language-as-resource. Building on an assimilationist mindset, the problem orientation sees the speaking of a language other than the dominant one as a deficit to be fixed (de Jong et al., 2016; Hult & Hornberger, 2016). The right orientation, on the other hand, departs from a monolingual standpoint and foregrounds the pervasiveness of language in social life. Specifically, this means that discrimination on the basis of language can have considerable negative effects on many other areas. Ruiz, though, questions the effectiveness of the right orientation in promoting linguistic diversity, highlighting its potential danger in deepening divisions instead of overcoming them.

To go beyond language-as-problem and language-as-right, an alternative orientation that Ruiz proposed is language-as-resource, which sees languages as resources to be cultivated and promoted. In theory, the resource orientation presents a win–win situation that caters to the interests of both the minority and the majority in a given context. In practice, however, several scholars raise concerns regarding the militarization and commodification of language in discourses related to resource, and whether they actually lead to social change or merely perpetuate the status quo (Kaveh, 2023; Petrovic, 2005; Ricento, 2005). The resource orientation—if hijacked by neoliberal ideologies—can easily turn into "feel-good" mechanisms that exploit the minority for the greater benefit of the majority while looking benevolent (Kaveh, 2022). Such outcomes are not uncommon in reality: teachers in the US demonstrate contradicting tensions between celebrating bi/multilingualism and fostering monolingualism in teaching and in testing (i.e., minoritized language used as a temporary solution for the development of English) (Kaveh, 2022; Zúñiga, 2016), community languages are positioned as ancillary to the dominant languages in the European job market (Easlick, 2022), languages of migrant workers become appropriated by the state for national development in South Korea (Sohn & Kang, 2021), and linguistic diversity strategically preserved in China as a means to strengthen political stability (de Jong et al., 2016; Shen & Gao, 2019). The resource orientation, therefore, may undermine its own goal of achieving linguistic justice.

To foreground the social justice dimension in the resource orientation, de Jong et al. (2016) introduced the idea of "bi/multilingualism as resource". This re-orientation of the resource dimension re-centers a number of key questions in language policy and planning: What languages are seen as resource? What counts as resource? Are they equally valued? Who decides what is resource? Resource for whom and for what (Delavan et al., 2017; Easlick, 2022; Hult & Hornberger, 2016; Kaveh, 2022, 2023; Petrovic, 2005; Ricento, 2005; Zúñiga, 2016)? While Ruiz (1984) sought to move away from deficit-oriented thinking toward asset-based approaches, orientations in nature are shifting, intersectional, and multilayered, rather than sequential or mutually-exclusive (Bale, 2016; de Jong et al., 2016; Kaveh, 2023; Petrovic, 2005; Zúñiga, 2016). What is highlighted in recent developments of Ruiz's work is to consider issues of power—such as colonialism, capitalism, racism, nationalism, neoliberalism—in policy discourse, so that spaces for minoritized languages in society can be opened up (Hult & Hornberger, 2016).

Research design

To explore the public's response towards Bilingual 2030, I now turn to explain how the ideological dimension of language in public discourse is identified and interrogated in this study. As mentioned in the introduction, examining public discourse offers illuminating findings that expose desires and contradictions in how people think about language. Such discourse—when analyzed critically—may unveil orientations about language (i.e., problem, right, resource). The following subsections provide details of the methods adopted for data collection and approaches to data analysis.

Data collection methods

To capture the public's voice as comprehensively as possible within manageable boundaries, three types of data were utilized in this study: opinion pieces, polls, and comments gathered from a petition related to Bilingual 2030. These sources, though each having their own limitations (e.g., sampling, editorial, or moderation bias), are some of the most important channels through which people express their policy viewpoints in Taiwan. The main bulk of the data are the opinion pieces and petition comments as they carry rich qualitative information (e.g., the reasoning behind particular perspectives), while the poll results—due to their more general nature—are treated as background data for comparison. All data are publicly accessible.

Specifically, the selection of the opinion pieces went through two rounds of screening: in the first round, keywords including "bilingual policy", "bilingual nation", and "bilingual education" were typed into the search box of the web archives of three major newspapers in Taiwan: United Daily News, China Times, and The Liberty Times. These newspapers offer a discursive venue for the public to share their opinions; at the same time, the opinions are also mediated as they are published only after obtaining approval from the newspaper editors.[3] The time frame of the search was set between January 2019 and December 2022. In the second round, only articles that met the following criteria were kept: (1) the title of the article must contain "bilingual", (2) the content of the article has to be related to Taiwan's bilingual policy, and (3) there must be a clear indicator that the article belongs to "opinion pieces" or "guest essays". In other words, the authors are outside contributors, either invited to share their opinions, or they voluntarily submitted the articles themselves. Finally, articles that are advertisements, re-posted articles from other platforms, or with authors whose identity are unclear were removed. This yielded 31 opinion pieces in total: two in 2019, eight in 2020, ten in 2021, and eleven in 2022 (the opinion pieces are numbered as OP1, 2, 3…). All articles selected are in Chinese, and the word count ranged from 419 to 2221.

[3] The extent of circulation and revenue that the opinion could generate may affect whether one's opinion is approved. Additionally, editors may also take into consideration the political affiliation of the author.

In addition to the data collected from the opinion pieces, comments from a petition initiated by the "English-friendly, multilingual Taiwan" alliance were examined. The petition, filed in April 2023 on the National Development Council's public policy online participation platform, can be viewed as the second generation of the petition organized in 2022. Highlighting the negative effects of the policy on education at all levels and its inconsistencies with the National Languages Development Act, this updated petition called for an end to Bilingual 2030. The petition obtained the minimum 5000 signatures in three days, prompting relevant government bodies to respond to the call. Although the petition in the end did not change the overall trajectory of the policy itself, the comment section under the petition shows interesting insights into people's thoughts about the policy. All comments—a total of 246 entries—were included in this study (the petition comments are listed as PC1, 2, 3…). Similar to the opinion pieces, all comments are primarily in Chinese. The word count, however, was smaller, between 2 and 931.

Finally, results from four opinion polls related to Bilingual 2030 were further incorporated into the data set. Since 2018, several polls have been launched to investigate public perceptions on the policy itself or bilingual education more specifically (see Liao et al., 2024, for a more comprehensive analysis of all opinion polls). For this study, the four polls included were conducted either by non-governmental organizations or academic foundations. Three of them targeted the general public, whereas one focused on student voices. The polls were identified by consulting a few scholars who have written extensively about language policy topics in Taiwan. Additionally, the polls selected have details of data collection available to the public (i.e., sample size and questions that were asked); hence, if such information could not be identified, the polls were not considered (i.e., those from Yahoo!).

Data analysis

After presenting the poll results in the first part of the findings, major themes related to (1) English, (2) Mandarin, (3) national languages in Taiwan (with a focus on languages aside from Mandarin), and 4) other foreign languages (with a focus on languages aside from English) in both the opinion pieces and petition comments are shared. The themes emerged after conducting a combination of keyword analysis, thematic analysis, and critical approaches to discourse analysis. With Ruiz's framework guiding how the data were read, these together helped provide a contour of the public's complex language orientations (i.e., as problem, right, resource), or what Milani and Johnson (2010) call "sociolinguistic imagination".

Here I turn to explain the details of data analysis. In the early stages, descriptions of each language category (English, Mandarin, national languages in Taiwan, and other foreign languages) were coded through keyword analysis. This meant that texts accompanying the named languages (sentences that were semantically coherent) were extracted with the use of NVivo. Once the texts for each language category were compiled, they were read repeatedly following general guidelines of thematic analysis (Nowell et al., 2017). The texts were compared and refined until a sense of "saturation" was reached. This was when the final themes were developed.

As the purpose of this study is to examine language orientations in public discourse, the coding process shared many similarities with critical approaches to discourse analysis (Fairclough, 2010; Wodak & Meyer, 2015). The analysis is critical because the process makes explicit the normative nature of public discourse, and positions public discourse not as existing independently on its own, but as having internal and external relations with other social phenomena (Rogers, 2011). The critical dimension was applied by paying attention to the relationship between the themes that have emerged and the textual features of the opinion pieces and petition comments. Some questions that guided the analysis include: What characteristics are attributed to languages and their speakers? What language practices are considered normal, typical, or given? What claims of truth or rightness are presented? What emotions are invoked and what arguments are employed? Specifically, these questions entail an awareness of a number of discursive strategies that generate certain effects. These strategies could be the use of evaluative stances (e.g., value markers that show how a language is perceived), pronouns (e.g., the use of "we" to indicate affiliation with a linguistic community), modals (e.g., words that suggest what should be done to a language), metaphors (e.g., a figure of speech that triggers a mental image of a language), or reference to authority (e.g., texts, figures, or concepts that highlight what is happening to a language) (Ashraf, 2014; Wodak & Meyer, 2015). Taking a critical perspective, therefore, not only helps unveil how the public responds to the idea of "becoming bilingual", but also how specific languages are constructed and represented by the public.

Findings

In the findings, I first present results from four key opinion polls to provide a glimpse of the public's response towards Bilingual 2030 (see Table 1). Then, I share in-depth, qualitative analysis of the data collected from the opinion pieces and petition comments. To tease out more fine-tuned language orientations held by the public, I organize this section by language categories, in the order of English, Mandarin, national languages in Taiwan, and other foreign languages (language categories mentioned the most come first). Arranging the data in this manner allows for more bottom-up expression of people's viewpoints, as orientations are embedded in discussions around language and often intersectional and multilayered. The extracts included in the findings have all been translated to English. The sources of the quotes are indicated in the brackets at the end of the quotes.

English

From both the opinion pieces and petition comments, it is clear that English carries two opposing qualities: on the one hand, English is considered a resourceful language; on the other hand, it is also viewed as a threat, especially when imposed too hastily through top-down interventions.

Table 1 Results from key opinion polls on Bilingual 2030

	Year	Org	Focus of the poll	Method	Results related to the bilingual policy
1	2018	Professor Huang Kun-huei Education Foundation	The polls examined education values of Taiwanese nationals. Specifically, two of the areas surveyed were on bilingual education and making English the second official langauge	Computer-assisted telephone interview (CATI) (sample size: 1071)	89% of the participants were in favor of promoting bilingual education, in contrast with 6.1% who were against it. 87% expressed agreement to the proposal to make English the scond official language in Taiwan, while 9% disagreed
2	2020	Professor Huang Kun-huei Education Foundation	This was a follow-up poll from the one administered in 2018. The only area related to the bilingual policy is making English the second official langauge	CATI (sample size: 1070)	88.1% expressed agreement to the proposal to make English the second official language in Taiwan, while 9% disagreed
3	2023	Grassroots Impact	The poll explored how the public percieves the education policies introduced by the current government, focusing on the New Curriculum Guideline and Bilingual 2030	CATI (sample size: 1111)	Approximately two thirds of the participants highlighted issues related to 1) teacher preparedness for bilingual education, 2) the learning outcomes of implementing bilingual education, and 3) widening attainment gaps resulting from bilingual education
4	2023	EdYouth	The poll, targeting secondary school students, looked into students' views on Bilingual 2030 and English learning	The poll included two rounds: the first was open-ended (sample size: 194), whereas the second required partcipants to respond to a Likert scale (sample size: 831)	Key themes from the first round were aspirations to improve one's English and become more globally competitive; however, there were many concerns pertaining to language and identity, resource distribution, and the impact of the policy on subject learning as well as English learning itself. The theme mentioned the most was the incompatibility of the bilingaul policy (which emphasizs English) with the New Curriculum Guideline (which emphasizes multilingual education)

Specifically, in a number of the opinion pieces, English is described as playing an important—if not most important—role in sharpening one's competitiveness, facilitating international/intercultural communication, and gaining access to the world (e.g., for travel, business, and study abroad). The conceptualization of English-Mandarin bilingualism, according to some, may further help improve "national security, and [serve as a stepping stone for Taiwan] to form democratic alliances with the United Kingdom and the United States" (OP24). In such discussions, the emotion that English generates is a feeling of hope and liberation.

However, different from the rosy picture painted by the optimists, several salient themes related to the dangerous side of English can be identified not only in the opinion pieces, but even more so in the petition comments. To be clear, it is not English per se that is threatening, but the bilingual policy's heavy emphasis on English (e.g., prioritizing English over subject knowledge in teacher recruitment; allowing English to be used as a medium of instruction in kindergartens). In particular, the most widely mentioned concern is the threat to learning outcomes. Many of these concerns are expressed in the form of rhetorical questions in the petition comments, as displayed below.

> Learning math, physics, and chemistry in Mandarin is already challenging. Can you imagine what it would be like in English? (PC72)

> If the only few fun courses students can take are in a language they are unfamiliar with, how much would they actually understand??? Do they have a chance to speak??? Will they think these courses are fun anymore??? (PC29)

> Now we're also asked to incorporate classroom English into different subject areas…all for creating an "immersive" English learning experience. Isn't this going too far…??? (PC147)

The rhetorical questions (and series of question marks) indicate how frustrated and exasperated the public is with the situation: not only does the forceful integration of English into other content areas take away time to focus on subject knowledge itself, but also meaningful classroom participation. The disproportionate attention placed on English, they warn, can even worsen urban–rural and class-based divides.

Aside from the threat to learning outcomes, English is often viewed as harmful to the learning of one's mother tongue and how one positions him/herself in relation to the world. Many frightening metaphors are evoked to describe English, such as a "monster out of its cage" (OP11) or a "supernatural creature" that is "impossible to tame" and "out of our reach" (OP18). As one's mother tongue is closely tied to issues of identity, the penetration of English further raises questions related to who Taiwanese are, and even anxieties over self-colonization. A note to mention is that such discussions do not necessarily imply an inward-looking, nationalist ideology, but that internationalization should not be confused with English. An extract from one of the opinion pieces elaborates this clearly.

> If internationalization means having a broader vision, then English doesn't always play a role in this. In fact, if English is the only language taken into

> consideration, the tendency to place Anglo-American values at the center narrows our vision, which can diminish other meaningful possibilities for internationalization. (OP21)

From what the extract suggests, English can be seen as a vessel for transmitting Anglo-American values, and sometimes wrongfully equated with internationalization. While English may bring many touted benefits, a constant reminder from critics of English is to move from an obsession with English to thinking beyond English.

Mandarin Chinese

Similar to English, the role of Mandarin in the opinion pieces and petition comments is somewhat ambivalent: although Mandarin is still the dominant language in Taiwan, its projected status seems to be uncertain when placed in competition with English.

In the opinion pieces, Mandarin is described as the primary language that Taiwanese communicate with in their everyday lives—and the language of education specifically. In addition to its wide usage, Mandarin is frequently depicted as the root language of the people in Taiwan. Such emphasis on Mandarin in the formation of the Taiwanese identity can be seen in the adoption of the pronoun "our" to highlight membership within an imagined community. A few examples from the petition comments illustrate this point.

> Our country's mother tongue is Mandarin. (PC93)

> The writing system of our country is Traditional Chinese. If this is the case, learning Mandarin is enough. If people are interested in—or good at—learning other languages, they can do it themselves and make it their profession. (PC89)

> I really hope that our Traditional Chinese won't disappear one day. I'm very proud of our Traditional Chinese and Zhuyin phonetic system. (PC115)

While claiming ownership of Mandarin may elevate the perceived importance of Mandarin in Taiwan, some authors in the opinion pieces go further to draw attention to the sophisticated aesthetic appeal of Chinese characters, texts, and literature—as well as how they embody rich Chinese culture—to show pride in having Mandarin as their L1. These features are reiterated not only to deepen the influence of Mandarin in Taiwan, but also to explain why Mandarin is becoming an increasingly popular language around the world.

In spite of the dominant status of Mandarin, there seems to be, nevertheless, a concern that it is threatened by English, or that it can be threatened *even more* by English in the longer run. It is not uncommon to hear the Taiwanese public lamenting how the young generation's Mandarin is getting worse. There is also the concern that English is taking away the teaching hours for Mandarin, or English encroaching

the space where Mandarin is usually prioritized (e.g., when Chinese departments attempt to hire EMI faculty). Importantly, the threat to Mandarin can be more than a language issue: for those who see Mandarin as a carrier of their Chinese identity, English may additionally be seen as a linguistic tool to de-Sinicize Taiwan. Such sentiments regarding language, education, and culture are equally reflected in the petition comments, as encapsulated in the following extract. While the recruitment of international students seems to necessitate the use of English, the commenter here raises a pertinent point:

> Why don't foreign students learn Mandarin when they come to Taiwan, but instead ask local students to accommodate? This is already a tragedy in higher education, and now we're seeing the government bringing this to more foundational levels of education. If we switch many terminologies that can be more clearly communicated in Mandarin to English, imagine what this would do to Taiwan's education, culture, and society. I advise the government not to pander to the US all the time or make Taiwan a sub-state of the US. (PC83)

The strong language in this extract (e.g., "tragedy" and "pander to") show that language issues are often emotionally charged. This is especially perceptible in Taiwan as tensions between Mandarin and English tend to be entangled in Taiwan's ambivalent position between China and the US. This will be detailed further in the next section.

National languages in Taiwan

As national languages in Taiwan include Mandarin, Tâi-gí, Hakka, indigenous languages, and Taiwan Sign Language, they are frequently labeled as "mother tongue" or "local language" in the opinion pieces and petition comments. The words "mother" and "local" reinforce the idea that these languages are what grandparents use, or less spoken by the younger generation. Furthermore, they are seen as linked to Taiwan's cultural foundation, and even connected to our "soul" (OP25).

In particular, while a few authors and commenters proactively use the term "multilingual" to describe Taiwan, many of them do not necessarily have all national languages in mind when they use the term "mother tongue" or "local language". From the petition comments specifically, it is not difficult to notice that the call for terminating the bilingual policy could actually stem from a monolingual ideology (e.g., when non-Mandarin national languages are viewed as redundant). Zooming into the opinion pieces, in some cases mother tongue only refers to Mandarin; in other cases, it may prioritize Tâi-gí, Hakka and Tâi-gí combined, or indigenous languages along with Mandarin. There are, too, cases where Mandarin is excluded in the "mother tongue" or "local language" label, especially when the authors want to highlight the fragile status of the minoritized languages in Taiwan, or make a distinction between the languages that existed before and after the Chinese Nationalists' occupation of Taiwan.

The key theme that emerged in the descriptions surrounding "mother tongue" and "local language" is that these languages are perceived as weaker and under threat. There are, however, two interesting differences: if Mandarin is included in discussions of mother tongue, English is seen as the threat; yet, if Mandarin is excluded in discussions of mother tongue, then both Mandarin and English are threats. Here, I juxtapose two extracts to illustrate these differences.

> In Singapore, most young people cannot and are also not interested in learning their grandparents' language. Local mother tongues have become like foreign language subjects in schools. Because of this inter-generational language barrier, Singapore faces serious problems with preserving their cultural heritage. […] if English (officially) enters Taiwan, it'll maintain its dominant status and become a so-called 'high language'. Competing in the language ecology of Taiwan, all other local languages under the bilingual policy will become 'low languages'. High languages too often end up replacing low languages. When low languages face extinction, they cannot be saved; we can only watch them die. (OP11)

> The bilingual policy kills mother tongues. My two highly-educated colleagues from the Philippines tell me they grew up learning in English. Although they have their writing system, at school their mother tongue was never taught, making them illiterate in their own language. […] The difficult situation Tâi-gí is facing is the same. Taiwan is embedded in many unresolved colonial structures. The outer layer of Chinese colonization hasn't even been removed, and now we're trying to colonize ourselves with English. (OP31)

The authors in the two extracts have incorporated comparative examples from other countries in Asia to make their point. In the first extract, Singapore is mentioned as a case *not to become like* (mother tongues relegated to a lower status than English), although for advocates of the bilingual policy, Singapore is a role model to look up to (becoming bilingual in English and one's mother tongue). Sensational descriptions (e.g., "we can only watch them die") and references to academic terms (e.g., "high" and "low" languages) are further invoked to add weight to the argument that local languages are in danger. In the second extract, the Philippines is brought in to explain a more complex picture: the combination of English plus one powerful local language—not just English—are sources of threat to the vitality of an existing language ecology. In the competition for resources, languages are placed in a hierarchy under multiple layers of colonization; the languages in the lower rung face exceptionally challenging conditions just to survive. In both extracts, it is clear that the designation of "foreign" and "local" are not fixed: while mother tongues can be treated like foreign language subjects in the school curriculum (the case in Singapore), a colonizer's language, too, can become indigenized and dominating (like Mandarin in Taiwan).

Other foreign languages in Taiwan

In contrast with national languages in Taiwan, foreign languages in both the opinion pieces and petition comments are perceived as "alien" or "non-mother tongue", unfamiliar to the locals and rarely used in people's everyday lives. Many examples show that foreign language is discussed interchangeably with English, and specifically American English. Because of the English focus, in these cases "foreign languages" are seen as somewhat threatening.

In a small set of other cases, though, English is understood—and explicitly mentioned—as forming only a part of the many foreign languages in Taiwan. Some authors of the opinion pieces highlight "second foreign language" or "other second languages" to make a distinction from English. These languages may include (1) popular European languages such as German, Spanish, and French; (2) existing or increasingly powerful regional languages in Asia, like Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese, and Indonesian, and (3) programing language. The emphasis on promoting foreign language diversity is also visible in the petition comments.

In general, learning foreign languages is perceived by the public as having many cognitive and social benefits. The challenge in foreign language education is to decide what languages to prioritize and how to balance them with the development of local languages. To dilute anxieties over English, one option proposed is to recenter intercultural communication in foreign language education, as manifested in the following quote: "What we choose is not English, but an international lingua franca. What we choose is not the existing English hegemony, but a new form of multiculturalism through fostering intercultural understanding" (OP18). In this well-intentioned conceptualization, English is the carrier of any value or knowledge, free from all colonial baggage. While the conceptualization seeks to go beyond essentialist linkages between language and culture, it inadvertently reinforces the centrality of English in international communication, running the risk of erasing other embodied ways of seeing, knowing, and thinking.

Discussion

The data collected from the polls, opinion pieces, and petition comments create a rich picture of the public's response towards Bilingual 2030. In the following sections, I first discuss the findings more explicitly with Ruiz's (1984) framework of language orientations, and based on the complex language orientations presented, I then offer some suggestions for advancing multilingual Taiwan.

The public's imagination of becoming bilingual: the relational nature of language orientations

The public's imagination of becoming bilingual is not limited to the policy vision of English-Mandarin bilingualism (with English at the center). As an overview, the

polls display a broad scan of the public's reaction towards pre-determined agendas set by different organizations or foundations, while the opinion pieces and petition comments unveil a qualitative depiction of the public's language assumptions, aspirations, and concerns. An important aspect to notice is a disconnect between what is projected in policy discourse and what is received by the public, moving from an English-as-resource focus to a more dynamic discussion of resource, right, and problem orientations associated with different languages in Taiwan. In other words, although the English-as-resource orientation has sustained since Bilingual 2030 was introduced, the relational nature of diverse orientations—embedded in language ecologies that are structured by hierarchies of power—is a key feature that stood out in the data.

From the findings, English is considered the most resourceful language compared to other language categories. Not only is it frequently perceived as the only foreign language in Taiwan, but also seen as highly marketable in the global field. In particular, English is primarily taken as a resource for economic advancement, and additionally for national security and democracy (Chang, 2022; Hsu, 2021; Yeh, 2023). On the micro level, many individuals willingly or unwillingly subscribe to the belief that English is indispensable to human capital development, a belief strengthened by the rise of globalization and larger neoliberal influences contributing to the commodification of English (Kaveh, 2023; Petrovic, 2005; Ricento, 2005; Zúñiga, 2016). On the macro level, English is often conflated with progressive liberal values, in which Taiwan takes pride to differentiate itself from an increasingly authoritarian, ethno-nationalist China (Hsu, 2021; Yeh, 2023). In this sense, while the resourcefulness of English is held by the general public, including those who critique it, the desire for English is further enhanced by the interest of the state.

Turning to the right orientation, Mandarin, Tâi-gí, Hakka, indigenous languages and Taiwan Sign Language tend to be viewed as "mother tongue" or what represents "local". Specifically, these are languages that are key to fostering a sense of self-esteem and ensuring cultural self-reproduction (Davies & Dubinsky, 2018; Hult & Hornberger, 2016; Price, 2020; Ricento, 2005; Tsui & Tollefson, 2007). In spite of the official codification of all national languages in 2019, the findings show that merely establishing their legal foundation has not been sufficient for maintaining or developing their vitality. This is especially the case for minoritized languages that are still struggling to find breathing space between Mandarin and English. Echoing what Ruiz (1984) argued, it would be naïve to exclude the instrumental dimension in considerations of language rights. Such a dimension is concerned with improving one's "meaningful participation in public institutions and democratic processes, and to the enjoyment of social and economic opportunities that require linguistic skills" (Rubio-Marín, 2003, p. 56).

In the process of balancing the resource orientation and the right orientation, it is also interesting to see a strong problem orientation shaping the public's policy response. The main problem identified among the public is Bilingual 2030's disproportionate focus on English, which is perceived as the principal threat to the local language ecology and potentially to one's national or ethnic identity. For some, Mandarin—the dominant language in Taiwan—is treated as an ongoing threat, too. These concerns make Taiwan frequently placed in comparison with Singapore (Lu,

2021) and the Philippines (Tupas & Martin, 2017), as the privileged status of English—or English plus another powerful local language—relegate other languages to a lower status over time. From the findings, this is not a path that the Taiwanese public seem to want; there are, nevertheless, a few people who optimistically believe that elevating the status of English would not do any harm. Indeed, not all Taiwanese see the learning of other national languages as a need, either. While most people would not go as far as to prohibit the use of these languages in the public space or reject one's right to his/her "mother tongue", they tolerate and accept linguistic diversity, but only as long as the status quo is safely preserved. In other words, it is unclear what levels of commitment the public has towards the promotion and celebration of such diversity.

Responding to the public's conceptualization of bilingualism: suggestions for advancing multilingual Taiwan

As presented in the previous section, the public's language orientations are relational, shifting, and multilayered, implicated in larger language dynamics (Bale, 2016; de Jong et al., 2016; Kaveh, 2023; Petrovic, 2005; Zúñiga, 2016). While there is ample discussion around the economic benefits of English (English-as-resource), issues related to national identity (national languages-as-right, either with Mandarin included or excluded) and de/colonization (English and/or Mandarin-as-problem) are also very much alive and kicking in interpretations of Bilingual 2030. Such issues resonate with much of the existing literature looking into the intersection of language, culture, and nation (Davies & Dubinsky, 2018; Kamusella, 2018; Tsui & Tollefson, 2007), as well as publications on language politics in Taiwan before or after Bilingual 2030 was introduced (Chang, 2022; Dupré, 2014; Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Hsu, 2021; Liao, 2022; Yeh, 2023). Zooming into responses to Bilingual 2030, this paper highlights that the public's imagination of "becoming bilingual" is complex: those who are in favor of the policy may interpret bilingualism in multilingual or monolingual ways (depending on whether it is bi/multilingualism or English that they see in the policy), and those who are against the policy may do so for promoting multilingualism or the opposite (rejecting the policy because it is not bi/multilingual enough or because there is more interest in prioritizing a monolingual ethnonationalist agenda). Although policymakers argue that the parallel development of Bilingual 2030 and the National Languages Development Act ensures a balanced resource distribution between the so-called "international lingua franca" and all mother tongues in Taiwan, the lack of thorough planning involved in Bilingual 2030—in both its conceptualization and operationalization—does not seem to be in harmony with the spirit proposed in the National Languages Development Act (Ferrer & Lin, 2021; Liao, 2022). Between supporting and resisting Bilingual 2030, Taiwan still needs to seriously consider how it can strengthen multilingualism in Taiwan—not just on the state level, but also among its people. Here I share some broad suggestions for working towards this vision.

First, the multilingual nature of Taiwan should be prioritized in all forms of language planning. As stated in the National Languages Development Act (2018),

natural languages spoken by all ethnic groups in Taiwan and Taiwan Sign Language have the right to be recognized, protected, and promoted. Other language policies that carry state level significance, if introduced, must clearly articulate their relationship with the Act—in both symbolic and material terms. In the process of nation-building, it may also be more meaningful for Taiwan to linguistically rebrand itself as a rightfully multilingual state, rather than limiting itself to English-Mandarin bilingualism (Hsia, 2023; Yeh, 2023). This would entail making all languages in Taiwan as both resource *and* right to its people (e.g., for education, employment, legal representation, political participation, access to welfare services, expression of one's cultural identity). The aim is to continue foregrounding principles of diversity, equality, and social justice in language policymaking—values emphasized in Bale (2016), Delavan et al. (2017), and Kaveh (2023)—for improving the lives of all Taiwanese and those who have chosen to call Taiwan home.

Second, more deliberate debates on language issues should be opened up, especially in places like Taiwan that proudly calls itself democratic. Such debates require in-depth, transparent, and long-term discussion represented by all parties affected, as policy discourse and public discourse are constantly involved in each other's production, distribution, and consumption. According to Chang (2022), engaging in bottom-up dialogue helps policymakers "understand the causes and forces contradicting and challenging the hegemonic, institutionally imposed national identity, and learn about creative strategies with which people are already preparing themselves for the globalized community—with or without the mastery of English" (p. 142). In other words, the role of all languages in Taiwan would need to be unpacked, and alternative interpretations of the Taiwanese identity would also need to be made possible. Moving from reactionary comments targeting Bilingual 2030 to wider language plans for the future, questions to ponder are: if Taiwan is a rightfully multilingual state, are there any languages that should be placed at the center (e.g., to be given "official" status, allocated more time in the national curriculum, or assigned as a medium of instruction)? If yes, what are they and why? Without deliberate debates, it would be difficult to build consensus among the public, and without a common ground, it would be impossible to devise appropriate strategies that can respond to the linguistic needs, hopes, and desires of the people.

Conclusion

In this paper I have proposed two research questions, one seeking to map out the public's response towards Bilingual 2030, and the other examining what "becoming bilingual" means to the public. To address these questions, data were collected through the analysis of opinion pieces, polls, and petition comments, and with the support of Ruiz's (1984) conceptualization of language orientations. The findings show that the public's language orientations are relational, intersecting, and multilayered. They further unveil a disconnect between what is projected (an English-as-resource focus in policy discourse) and what is received (a more dynamic discussion of resource, right, and problem orientations associated with different languages in Taiwan). I end the paper with two broad suggestions: first, that the multilingual

nature of Taiwan should be prioritized in all forms of language planning; and second, that more deliberate, transparent, and bottom-up debates on language issues should be opened up. To continue exploring what the public "thinks about" Bilingual 2030, other forms of data collection—such as conducting social media analysis or focus group interviews—could further yield rich insights into language policymaking for the future.

To be clear, my purpose in this paper is not to dismiss the many efforts that have been invested to widening the distribution of English in Taiwan in the past few years. What I intend to do is to expand the dialogue with language educators, researchers, and policymakers by asking whether it is only English that should be at the center of discussing Taiwan's bilingual vision, and if not, how bi/multilingualism should be practiced and promoted in our everyday lives. Indeed, in this paper I have barely scratched the surface of issues related to neoliberalism, nationalism, and de/colonialization in language debates; deeper exploration of each of these issues may help policy stakeholders make sense of the beliefs that people hold. This is significant not only for language policymaking in Taiwan, but also for other contexts that are seeing similar challenges emerging from ongoing cultural, demographic, and political changes that have linguistic effects. As policymaking does not always follow a linear, rationale process, McGroarty (2006) advises stakeholders to "constantly articulate the value of bilingualism, and be able to do so in varied terms that respond to a protean environment of public discussion" (pp. 5–6). The goal for formulating a socially-just language policy—at its core—is to enrich the range of alternatives for advancing bi/multilingualism, and keep these alternatives alive in the policy stream as well as in the public consciousness.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest The author reports there are no competing interests to declare.

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